

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 7, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

MARIMAR MARTINEZ SHOOTING

Judge allows release of evidence

Ruling determines Chicago woman has right to counter federal government's 'terrorist' claims

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Saying the federal government has shown "zero concern" about ruining the reputation of a Chicago woman shot by a Border Patrol

agent, a federal judge on Friday agreed to lift a protective order and allow the release of body-camera footage and text messages from the agent who shot her. In her ruling, which stems from one of the highest-profile incidents

of Operation Midway Blitz, U.S. District Judge Georgia Alexakis said Marimar Martinez has the right to counterbalance the label of "domestic terrorist" put upon her by the Department of Homeland security — a narrative the government has refused to retract even after assault charges against Martinez were dropped. "Ms. Martinez is a United

States citizen. She's a resident of this district. And under our legal system, she is presumed innocent of any offense of which she has not been convicted," Alexakis said in a courtroom packed with local and national media. Alexakis' ruling means Martinez's attorneys will be free to release reams of evidence in the case to the public that they say will

clear Martinez's name and show the government has been lying about the facts since the get-go. Among the evidence: body camera footage that allegedly shows a Border Patrol agent saying "do something, bitch," before their car collided with Martinez's vehicle in Brighton Park on Oct. 4, **Turn to Martinez, Page 2**



Trump's racist post of Obamas draws ire

Aide calls outrage 'fake' hours before removal of image

By Bill Barrow
and Josh Boak
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump's racist social media post featuring former President Barack Obama and his wife, Michelle Obama, as primates in a jungle was deleted after a backlash from both Republicans and Democrats who criticized the video as offensive.

The Republican president's Thursday night post was deleted Friday and blamed on a staffer after widespread backlash, from civil rights leaders to veteran Republican senators, for its treatment of the nation's first Black president and first lady.

The deletion, a rare admission of a misstep by the White House, came hours after press secretary Karoline Leavitt dismissed "fake outrage" over the post. After calls for its removal for being racist — including by Republicans — the White House said a staffer had posted the video erroneously and it had been taken down.

The post was part of a flurry of social media activity on Trump's Truth Social account that amplified his false claims that the 2020 election was stolen from him, despite courts around the country and a Trump attorney general from his first term finding no evidence of fraud that could have affected the outcome.

Trump has a record of intensely personal criticism of the Obamas and of using incendiary, sometimes racist, rhetoric — from feeding the lie that Obama was not a native-born U.S. citizen to crude generalizations about majority Black countries.

The post came in the first week of Black History Month and days after a Trump procla-

Turn to Post, Page 6

SHOW SOME MUSCLE

Chicago Auto Show back with plenty of EVs and a resurgence of gas-powered brawn

By Robert Channick | Chicago Tribune

In recent years, the Chicago Auto Show has been steering toward electric vehicles, following the ambitious state and national agenda to convert the industry from combustion engines to cleaner technology, incentivized by governmental tax credits and rebates.

While EVs are still center stage at the 2026 auto show, which opens today at McCormick Place, there may not be quite as much buzz this year with slumping sales and the end of federal tax credits under President Donald Trump.

In fact, some manufacturers are betting that old-school gas-burning muscle cars may steal the show. Ford, for example, is introducing the new 2026 Mustang Dark Horse SC, which harnesses a supercharged 5.2-liter V8 and seven-speed dual-clutch transmission to create a "track-capable" supercar. No word on how many miles it gets to the gallon.

The sleek blue model on display would likely blow the doors off the 1960s muscle cars it evokes, at least on a race course, according to Ryan Shaughnessy, Mustang brand manager.

"This takes Mustang to a new level," Shaughnessy said during the show's Friday media preview. "This is a new performance icon for Mustang. When you compare it to cars from the '60s, they don't really compare."

A more apt comparison for the Michigan-built Mustang might be the racing movie "Ford v Ferrari."

"It is intended to go after Europe's elite sports car competition, like Porsche and Mercedes, and to beat them," Shaughnessy said.

Closer to home, the automaker is also showcasing the Chicago-made 2026 Ford Explorer Tremor, a full-size SUV featuring a 3.0-liter EcoBoost V6 producing 400 horsepower. The Explorer is built at the century-old Chicago Assembly Plant on the city's Southeast Side.

Stellantis, which went on hiatus in 2024 but returned last year, is back again for the 2026 Chicago Auto Show. That means the return of its Jeep, Chrysler, Dodge, Fiat and Ram vehicles and the popular Camp Jeep test track, long an auto show favorite.

One attention-grabbing model is the 2027 Ram 1500 SRT TRX, billed as the "fastest, most powerful production gas pickup truck in the world,"

Turn to Muscle, Page 4

People ride in a 2026 Jeep Wrangler during the media preview day at the annual Chicago Auto Show at McCormick Place on Friday in the South Loop. **JOSH BOLAND/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ELECTION 2026 US SENATE

Democratic foes clash over PAC money, ICE abolition in heated primary debate

CONGRESSIONAL RACE IS 'WIDE OPEN': Rivals are taking jabs at the frontrunners in the race to represent Illinois' 2nd Congressional District. Cook County Commissioner Donna Miller is under fire for a large fundraising haul tied to AIPAC, and opponents continue to pounce on comeback-seeking former Rep. Jesse Jackson Jr., the best-known name in the primary campaign. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

By Rick Pearson
and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

The three leading Democrats in the March 17 U.S. Senate primary clashed Friday over how they finance their campaigns and proposed reforms to federal immigration enforcement operations as Congress debates a new funding bill for the Department of Homeland Security.

U.S. Reps. Robin Kelly and Raja Krishnamoorthi each called Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton a hypocrite,

arguing that while her campaign says it does not take money from corporate political action committees, independent PACs supporting her campaign do.

Stratton, the only candidate to call for abolishing the federal Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency over aggressive and controversial enforcement tactics, denied saying its duties could be handled by Customs and Border Protection — despite having told that to reporters after a Jan. 26 debate at

Turn to Senate, Page 4



Competing for a U.S. Senate seat, U.S. Reps. Robin Kelly, from left, and Raja Krishnamoorthi and Illinois Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton attend a public forum at the Chicago Journeymen Plumbers Local Union 130 UA headquarters in the West Loop on Friday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 24 Low 19

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 38 © Chicago Tribune

